THE STOLEN DOWRY TRUNK

Genre: Wedding & Clan Honor Drama
Cultural Context: Haryana / Western UP (Haryanvi / Khari Boli Context)
Characters: MEERA (21), VIKRAM (27), UNCLE RAJAN (55)

SCENE 1: INT. ANCESTRAL STORE ROOM - MORNING

Sunlight filters through iron grates onto stacked brass pots and heavy grain bins.

MEERA (21), slender, wearing an unstitched embroidered bridal lehenga, kneels before a massive iron-bound wooden trunk.

Her hands tremble as she slips a sealed document into the silk folds at the bottom of the trunk. The envelope header reads: "UNION MEDICAL RECRUITMENT BOARD - OFFICER SELECTION".

Footsteps approach. VIKRAM (27), her cousin and childhood confidant, enters holding a velvet jewelry case.

VIKRAM
The goldsmith delivered the necklace, Meera. Uncle Rajan wants you to wear it for the welcoming feast.

Meera snaps the heavy trunk lid shut. The brass latch rings sharply.

MEERA
Tell Uncle to keep his gold in his safe. I won't wear chains disguised as gifts.

VIKRAM
(stepping closer, noticing the latch)
What did you just hide in the dowry chest? If Uncle finds out you wrote the civil exam in secret, he will disown both of us before the wedding party arrives.

MEERA
Let him. My mother died laboring in his cotton gin. I won't spend my life scrubbing brass pots in a stranger's courtyard just to satisfy his clan pride.

Vikram looks at the closed trunk, torn between fraternal loyalty and fear of their patriarch.

SCENE 2: EXT. WEDDING MANDAP & COURTYARD - AFTERNOON

Marigold garlands sway in the dry afternoon breeze. Male elders sit on cushioned bolsters smoking hookah.

UNCLE RAJAN (55), barrel-chested, wearing an ornate silk turban and gold rings on four fingers, laughs loudly as he presents the keys of a tractor to the groom's father.

UNCLE RAJAN
In our clan, daughters leave the threshold like queens! Fifty tolas of gold and the latest diesel tractor. That is the honor of our lineage!

Vikram stands by the pillar, hands clenched, watching Meera emerge from the inner corridor without the ceremonial jewelry. A murmur ripples through the seated village elders.

UNCLE RAJAN
(voice hardening beneath a forced grin)
Meera. Where is the heirloom gold necklace your aunt placed in your dowry trunk this morning?

MEERA
The necklace is in the trunk, Uncle. Alongside the deed of debt you forced my father to sign on his deathbed.

The courtyard falls dead silent. The groom's family freezes. Rajan takes a threatening step toward her.

UNCLE RAJAN
You insolent girl! You speak like an unbridled stray in front of thirty clans! Go inside before I forget who brought you up!

SCENE 3: INT. INNER CEREMONIAL BAITHAK - SUNSET

The red twilight casts long shadows across the ceremonial carpet.

Uncle Rajan stands over Meera, his arm raised in fury. The heavy brass trunk sits open between them on the floor, its silk lining disturbed.

UNCLE RAJAN

You dare humiliate this house?! You will sign the marriage registry tonight or I will swear by the clan deity you never step foot in this village again!

Before his hand can strike, Vikram steps directly between them, his hand gripping his uncle's wrist with iron strength.

VIKRAM

That's enough, Uncle.

UNCLE RAJAN

(shocked, eyes bulging)

Vikram? You raise your hand against the head of the house? For an ungrateful girl?

VIKRAM

I am raising my hand for my sister. Look at what is inside that trunk, Uncle.

Meera pulls the government appointment order from the trunk and holds it up into the fading sunset light.

MEERA

First rank in the state medical council, Uncle. The Chief Magistrate signs my posting in the capital on Monday. I do not need your fifty tolas of gold to exist.

Uncle Rajan stares at the official government crest. The patriarchal authority dissolves from his face. Vikram takes Meera's duffel bag from behind the pillar.

VIKRAM

The car is at the canal road, Meera. You are going to the city.